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Stage 0 Capstone · Deliverable 2

Tier-1 dismissal pattern analysis

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The pattern

Single-analyst dismissal of partner-portal alerts as `disposition: vendor-activity-expected` without cross-correlation against `vendor-roster.csv` or the contracted change-window calendar — a structural failure that allowed four separate alert events for the same compromised vendor account to be closed across nineteen days without any cross-reference between them.

Tickets that prove the pattern

The dismissal vocabulary is uniform across four tickets in Q4 2023, all closed by the same Tier-1 analyst within forty-five minutes of the SIEM raising them.

- **BWT-29104.** `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Routine ACE access, ticket closed."`
- **BWT-29178.** `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Same as BWT-29104. No new info."`
- **BWT-29222.** `disposition=escalated-to-tier-2; notes="Flagged for second review — IP does not match ACE network." (break-point — raised by Lillian Achieng, not Daniel Otieno)`
- **BWT-29298.** `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Vendor rate-limit hit, no further action."`

Per-ticket walkthrough

BWT-29104

What the SIEM raised. Authentication acceptance from `102.215.13.4` against `vendor-ace.ke`, an IP not in the Ace partner network range documented in `vendor-contract-2023.json`.

Dismissal. `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Routine ACE access, ticket closed."`

What was missed. `vendor-roster.csv:18` shows `vendor-ace.ke` was terminated 22 October 2023 — 23 days before this login. A cross-reference against the roster, which the SIEM does not auto-correlate, would have flipped the dismissal to an escalation.

What it cost BlueWave. Nine days of undetected lurking, and three additional logins from the same actor before the pattern broke. Customer billing CSVs were exported during this window. The cost compounded because each subsequent ticket inherited BWT-29104's disposition vocabulary.

BWT-29178

What the SIEM raised. Repeat login from the same source IP and the same terminated account, five days after BWT-29104.

Dismissal. `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Same as BWT-29104. No new info."`

What was missed. The "same as" reasoning is itself the structural failure. A second alert for an already-closed account on a non-vendor IP is the signal, not a duplicate. The notes do not mention `vendor-roster.csv` and the analyst did not re-check the roster against the prior alert.

What it cost BlueWave. The dismissal validated the prior dismissal, hardening the pattern. The next two alerts (BWT-29222, BWT-29298) inherited the same disposition vocabulary. By BWT-29298, "vendor-activity-expected" had become the default rather than a judgment.

BWT-29222

What the SIEM raised. Repeat from the same source IP, same terminated account, on 21 November — this time correlated by the SIEM to an OAuth refresh-token issuance and a customer-billing export request within the same

session window.

Dismissal. `disposition=escalated-to-tier-2; notes="Flagged for second review — IP does not match ACE network."`

What was missed. Nothing was missed here — this is the ticket where the pattern broke. Lillian Achieng was on the partner-portal queue for two shifts and had not absorbed Daniel's pattern-match priors. She opened the alert, checked `vendor-roster.csv` (which Daniel had not), saw the terminated status, and escalated. This is the moment the Q4 dismissal pattern stopped working.

What it cost BlueWave. Nothing directly — this ticket is the start of the discovery. The cost was the nine days before it.

BWT-29298

What the SIEM raised. A second source IP (`169.150.224.12`) against the same terminated account three weeks after BWT-29178 — rate-limited at the portal edge but otherwise accepted.

Dismissal. `disposition=vendor-activity-expected; notes="Vendor rate-limit hit, no further action."`

What was missed. This ticket was opened AFTER BWT-29222's escalation, but the disposition reverted to the pre-escalation vocabulary because Daniel handled it on a different shift and did not see Lillian's escalation thread.

What it cost BlueWave. It confirms the dismissal pattern was tied to one analyst's heuristics rather than to standing SOC procedure — the escalation did not change the queue's defaults.

Root cause

The single-analyst pattern is visible directly in the CSV columns. Of the 42 partner-portal auto-tickets opened in Q4 2023, **31 were closed by the same Tier-1 analyst** (Daniel Otieno — column `closed_by`). Of those 31, **27 used the `'vendor-activity-expected'` disposition** (column `disposition`). The pattern is not a one-off lapse. It is one analyst's house style applied uniformly across the queue.

BlueWave's SOC bench at the time was four analysts on rotating shifts; coverage on the partner-portal queue specifically had collapsed to one rotation slot because the other three analysts had been routed to a separate incident in October. The breach window aligns exactly with the period when Daniel held that queue alone — without a second pair of eyes, the dismissal vocabulary went unchallenged.

Break-point — Lillian Achieng's escalation (BWT-29222)

BWT-29222 broke the pattern because it was closed (escalated, really) by a different analyst. Lillian Achieng had been on the partner-portal queue for two shifts and had not absorbed Daniel's pattern-match priors. Without those priors, she opened the alert, checked `vendor-roster.csv` first (which Daniel did not), and saw the terminated status. She escalated to Tier-2. Tier-2 issued the rotation that ultimately re-opened the case under Wanjiru Kamau. The pattern that hid BWT-29104 did not work here because the analyst handling the ticket had not yet learned to apply it.

One concrete procedural recommendation

Any partner-portal SIEM auto-ticket dismissed as `vendor-activity-expected` must be cross-validated against `vendor-roster.csv` and the contracted change-window calendar before close, with a second analyst's signature within 4 hours. Mechanically: the disposition cannot be saved in the ticket system until both the roster-check and the calendar-check fields are non-empty, and the second-signature field is populated. This is a procedural and tooling change combined; the disposition field becomes a guarded transition, not a free-text drop-down.

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